

« BEFORE

The fall of Phuoc Long province to North Vietnamese forces in January 1975 emboldened the leadership in Hanoi to pursue a final military victory over South Vietnam's President Thieu.

WEAKENED BY CUTS

South Vietnamese armed forces had been weakened by severe **cuts in American financial aid**, leading to shortages of fuel, munitions, and money for soldiers' pay. The United States had made it clear that no further military support could be expected. Meanwhile, North Vietnam's leaders, although remaining cautious, decided to mount a **spring offensive** in the Central Highlands.



SOUTH VIETNAMESE DEFENSES

Buon Ma Thuot was a provincial capital near the border with Cambodia. It had an army base and airfield, but in March 1975 was garrisoned only by a single ARVN infantry regiment and a Ranger Group, supplemented by Montagnard regional forces and militia. Holding the strategic initiative, the North Vietnamese forces were able to concentrate overwhelmingly superior forces against this poorly defended target, deploying three whole divisions in their attack.

Beginning on March 4, the NVA cut all the highways around Buon Ma Thuot, isolating the town. Then, with a swift infantry assault supported by heavy artillery, on March 10–11 they seized their objective. Ordered to retake Buon Ma Thuot, two ARVN regiments were airlifted to nearby Phuoc An, but instead of mounting a counterattack on the NVA, large numbers of demoralized South Vietnamese troops fled the scene, and joined a stream of civilian refugees attempting to escape the fighting.

Fateful decision

Faced with this crisis, on March 13 President Thieu made the fateful decision to abandon the defense of the Central Highlands and all of the northern provinces except the coastal enclaves. He envisaged a withdrawal to a line from Tay Ninh on the Cambodian border to the coast at Nha Trang. The area south of this line contained most of the country's